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Can community policing improve police-community relations in a low-income country setting?

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ABSTRACT

Community-oriented policing (COP) is one of the most widely touted mechanisms for building bridges between police forces and the communities they serve. But evidence on the effectiveness of COP is surprisingly scant. We present results from one of the first randomized controlled trials to evaluate the impact of COP in the Global South. The COP initiative we study was locally designed and funded by the Ugandan government. Contrary to our expectations, we find no evidence that the program reduced crime, enhanced citizens' perceptions of safety, improved their attitudes towards the police, increased crime reporting, or strengthened other norms of citizen cooperation with the police. Nor do we find evidence that the program generated greater empathy or accountability among participating police officers themselves. We explore a variety of potential explanations for these null results, including both supply-side factors (e.g., resource constraints within the Ugandan police force) and demand-side factors (e.g., citizens' fear of engaging with the police). We find no evidence that overcoming these obstacles would make COP more effective. Taken together, our findings point to potential limitations of COP in low-income countries.

1. Introduction

Community policing (or community-oriented policing, COP) has long been heralded as one of the most effective mechanisms for building trust and encouraging cooperation between police officers and citizens (Skogan and Hartnett, 1999). COP is believed to improve police-community relations by enhancing the quality and frequency of contact between citizens and the police (e.g., via town hall meetings) and by increasing community involvement in policing (e.g., via neighborhood watch teams), such that police officers and citizens “co-produce” local solutions to local security concerns. As relations improve, citizens may become more willing to cooperate with the police, and the police in turn may become better able to deter criminals (International Association of Chiefs of Police, 2015). Yet despite widespread adoption of COP globally (Brogden and Nijhar, 2013), its efficacy for reducing crime and increasing citizens' trust and cooperation with the police remains understudied and poorly understood, especially in low-income countries (Blair, Christia and Weinstein, 2024).

Most studies of COP focus on rich, industrialized democracies (e.g., Dunn et al., 2016; Peyton, Sierra-Arévalo and Rand, 2019). Findings

from these studies are mixed, with wide variation in both the components of the interventions being studied and the outcomes of interest (Blair et al., 2024). There is some evidence from systematic reviews that COP correlates with an improvement in citizen satisfaction with the police and an increase in perceived police legitimacy (Gill et al., 2014). A more recent meta-analysis finds that COP is also associated with a reduction in some crimes, such as burglary (Ekici et al., 2022). However, most of the studies included in these and other reviews are observational, creating serious inferential challenges. Evidence from low-income countries (LICs), observational or otherwise, remains limited (Blair et al., 2021).

This is an important gap, as it is unclear whether lessons learned from high-income countries will generalize to LICs. On the one hand, police forces in LICs operate under severe resource constraints and generally suffer from higher levels of corruption and nepotism (Tankebe, 2010) and lower levels of autonomy (Parfitt, Pantaleão and Kopitke, 2025). Relatedly, trust in the police also tends to be lower in LICs (Ruddell and Trott, 2023). COP may prove less effective in these contexts. On the other hand, positive interactions with the police may be more impactful in settings where such interactions are rare (Sukhtankar,

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Kruks-Wisner and Mangla, 2022; Hanson, Kronick and Slough, 2025), and citizen cooperation may be especially valuable where police forces are more resource-constrained (Blair, Karim and Morse, 2019), making COP more effective in LICs. How these countervailing forces balance out is an open question.

In this study we experimentally evaluate the impact of a locally designed and funded COP program in Uganda. Uganda offers an important test case for the effectiveness of COP in LICs. Most existing studies of COP (or COP-like) interventions in LICs have focused on countries where police forces are resource-constrained but where they are nonetheless (largely) insulated from political interference by democratically elected governments (Blair et al., 2019; Morse, 2025). This is not the case in electoral autocracies like Uganda—the most common regime type in the world, encompassing some 44% of the world's population (Boese et al., 2022). As is typical in such regimes, the Uganda Police Force (UPF) is subject to political influence, and the ruling party has a history of misusing the UPF's coercive capabilities to advance partisan goals (Grasse et al., 2021), especially in the months preceding national elections (Curtice and Berhlendorf, 2020).

Meanwhile, Ugandans of all political stripes face challenges of crime and insecurity that the UPF is constitutionally mandated to address. Based on conversations with citizens, police officers, and other stakeholders before the launch of our study, we posited that COP could improve citizens' perceptions of rank-and-file UPF officers at the local level and increase officers' responsiveness to the citizens they serve, even as the UPF, as a national-level institution, remains politicized. We also expected that establishing closer, more cooperative relationships between citizens and local UPF officers might mitigate crime and insecurity. To our knowledge, these propositions have not been rigorously tested in authoritarian settings.

The COP program we study was locally developed and funded, and it represents a realistic “best case” scenario for introducing core elements of COP in LICs. The UPF designed the program in collaboration with the Youth Integrated Development Organization (YIDO), a local civil society group with years of experience training Ugandan police officers. YIDO assisted with training the officers involved in the intervention. Crucially, while the UPF has received donor support for COP in the past (notably from USAID and Irish Aid), we did not fund the COP program we study here. The Ugandan government provided all the resources for COP, which the UPF had already embraced (at least in principle) prior to our evaluation. This is important both for the ethics of the study and for the scope of our findings: because the program was locally designed and funded, we can draw more reliable inferences about the likely effects of analogous homegrown attempts to introduce COP in similar contexts.

We study the effects of the program using a randomized controlled trial (RCT) and two waves of surveys (baseline and endline), in which we surveyed nearly 3,500 community residents, 288 village leaders (or LC1 chairpeople), and more than 200 police officers and commanders throughout rural Uganda.¹ Unusually for studies of COP, our data thus captures views on both the “supply side” and the “demand side” of community policing. We combine these surveys with administrative data on crime and allegations of police abuse, which we collated, digitized, and geocoded through repeated visits to UPF stations and posts around the country. We complement our quantitative data with qualitative insights gleaned from focus groups and detailed first-hand observations of town hall meetings recorded by YIDO and local researchers from Innovations for Poverty Action (IPA). We use these qualitative data to help contextualize our quantitative results. We discuss the study's

ethics and the precautions we took to limit risks below and in [Supplementary Information](#) (SI) Section B.

We report four key findings.² First, we find that Uganda's COP program successfully increased the frequency of interactions between citizens and the police, the prevalence of neighborhood watch teams (NWTs), and the frequency of NWT patrols. Second, despite this increase in police-community contact and NWT activity, we find that the program had weak or null effects on almost all of our pre-registered outcomes. Most notably, we find little to no evidence that the program increased citizens' approval of the UPF or improved their assessments of the intentions, capacity, or responsiveness of UPF officers. Third, we do not find evidence that the program strengthened UPF officers' sense of empathy or accountability towards the communities they serve. Fourth, perhaps unsurprisingly given our other results, we also find no evidence that the program reduced the prevalence of crime or increased citizens' subjective perceptions of safety.

Our study's null results run counter to our pre-registered hypotheses. We conduct extensive descriptive and heterogeneous treatment effect analyses to explore potential explanations for these disappointing findings, and to attempt to identify conditions under which COP might yield more promising results. We begin by ruling out the possibility that our findings are artifacts of flaws in our research design—in particular, spillover, attrition, low statistical power, and measurement error. We then consider a variety of possible “supply-side” explanations related to the UPF—including resource constraints, high officer turnover, low officer morale, and principal-agent problems arising from a lack of top-down supervision—as well as “demand-side” explanations related to the attitudes, behaviors, and demographics of citizens themselves (e.g., the “stickiness” of citizens' pre-treatment perceptions of the police).

None of these factors can easily explain our findings. For example, we do not find evidence that treatment effects are larger in stations that were relatively better resourced, suffered from less turnover, or were easier to supervise at baseline. These results suggest that addressing implementation challenges—which are inherent to COP programs worldwide, including in high-income countries (Gill et al., 2014)—may not be sufficient to ensure COP's success, at least in a setting like Uganda. We similarly find little to no evidence that treatment effects are stronger among citizens who expressed especially favorable (or unfavorable) views of the UPF at baseline; among those who tend to be disadvantaged under prevailing localized mechanisms of dispute resolution (e.g., women), and who therefore might have been more likely to benefit from increased police presence in their communities (Blair et al., 2019); or among those living in ruling party strongholds, who might have been more likely to expect (and perhaps receive) preferential treatment from the police. As we discuss in Section 7.4, it seems similarly unlikely that the program would have been more successful if the UPF had implemented more components of COP, or had implemented its existing components more aggressively.

As with any study focused on a single country, we cannot be sure how far our results will generalize. Nonetheless, the obstacles to COP in Uganda are endemic in LICs and are likely to arise in many developing country contexts where COP is currently being embraced (Blair et al., 2024). Indeed, these obstacles often emerge even in countries where police forces enjoy much more expansive resources than the UPF (Gill et al., 2014, 411). A recent meta-analysis of six community policing field experiments (including this one) in developing country settings reports similarly disappointing findings (Blair et al., 2021).³ We extend

¹ Our pre-analysis plan (PAP) was pre-registered before endline data collection, and is available at <https://osf.io/df3jk/overview>. We note that for logistical reasons, IPA surveyed 16 villages—roughly 5.5% of the sample—before we filed our PAP. The remaining 94.5% of villages were surveyed after we posted the PAP. We did not receive any endline data from IPA before we published the PAP on a public repository.

² All data and code used to produce the results reported in this article are available at dataverse.harvard.edu/dataset.xhtml?persistentId=doi:10.7910/DVN/DK9X4U&faces-redirect=true.

³ This meta-analysis incorporates data from Liberia and Uganda (low-income countries according to the World Bank's classification), Pakistan and Philippines (lower-middle income countries), and Brazil and Colombia (upper-middle income countries).

beyond this meta-analysis by rigorously testing an extensive set of potential explanations for COP's apparent null effects using a rich collection of covariates from administrative data and original panel surveys. Our findings suggest that addressing obstacles to COP on either the supply or demand side in contexts such as rural Uganda may not be enough to yield more positive results. We speculate that the effectiveness of COP in these settings may require more fundamental structural or cultural changes within the police force as a whole, or perhaps even broader political reforms in the country writ large (e.g., progress towards democratization). We return to this possibility in the conclusion, and consider other potential mechanisms for improving police-community relations in LICs.

2. Theoretical framework

Police forces are tasked with preventing crime and ensuring public safety. The more competently and fairly they accomplish these goals, the more legitimate they and the rest of the state apparatus are generally perceived to be (Sunshine and Tyler, 2003). In the best cases, citizens and the police establish a mutually beneficial equilibrium in which citizen cooperation improves police effectiveness, effective policing increases citizen trust, and citizen trust induces further citizen cooperation (Tankebe, 2009).

However, this mutually beneficial equilibrium often fails to materialize in practice. Citizens may refuse to cooperate with the police for many reasons, including concerns about police misconduct, fairness, or capacity, or social norms that discourage cooperation. When choosing whether to report crimes or otherwise assist the police, citizens likely weigh the expected costs against the expected benefits (Blair et al., 2019). In environments characterized by lack of accountability, corruption, and resource constraints, citizens may calculate that the costs of cooperation are simply too high. As a result, they may bypass the police altogether, relying instead on informal (non-state) authorities (Krakowski and Kursani, 2024) or extrajudicial mechanisms of dispute resolution (Wilke, 2026), or allowing crimes to go unsolved altogether.

These problems may be especially severe in authoritarian regimes, where the police are often (rightly) perceived as instruments of the ruling party. Even authoritarian governments rely on feedback from citizens to promote social welfare, provide public goods, and ensure regime stability (Tsai, 2003). But citizens who do not identify with the ruling party may be especially reluctant to engage with the police and may in some cases actively withhold information that they believe will be used against them and their communities. Of course, even in authoritarian settings, not all rank-and-file police officers are loyalists of the regime (Hassan, 2017), and many are at least nominally committed to providing security irrespective of citizens' partisan affiliations. But the reputation of the police force may spill over onto the reputations of individual officers, diminishing citizen cooperation and hindering police effectiveness.

2.1. The promise of community policing

Community-oriented policing (COP) aims to mitigate some of these challenges. COP is a law enforcement philosophy that emphasizes proactive problem solving and direct citizen participation in the co-production of security and public safety (Skogan, 2004, 2006). The concept first emerged in the 1970s, and by the 1990s it had been widely embraced by police departments in the US, UK, Australia, and other high-income countries. It has since spread to many LICs, as we discuss below. In theory, COP is not a policing strategy per se, but rather a "guiding framework for implementing strategies"—one that should be grounded in deep organizational and philosophical transformation within the police force as a whole (Gill et al., 2014, 402). In practice,

however, criminologists have long recognized that most police forces adopt "the language of community-oriented policing" without undergoing broader structural or philosophical reforms (Trojanowicz et al., 1998, 2), and that most police departments that "claim to be 'doing COP'" operationalize it as a "set of tactics employed by individual police officers, in specific beat areas, or by specialized teams" (Gill et al., 2014, 402–403). The intervention we evaluate follows a similar approach.

A wide variety of tactics fall under the umbrella of COP, including citizen police academies, in-service training for police officers, and voluntary citizen service within police departments (Ekici et al., 2022). The program we evaluate combines three of the most common tactics, each of which is expected to address one or more of the impediments to police-community relations described above. (We discuss the plausibility of these expectations in contexts like Uganda below.) First, **town hall meetings** create casual venues for citizens to ask questions and express concerns about security and related issues in their communities, and for police officers to hear citizens' concerns, work with them to devise solutions, encourage crime reporting and other forms of cooperation with the police, and convey information to help citizens navigate the criminal justice system. These meetings aim to generate "a significant amount of informal 'face time' between police and residents," which in turn is expected to build trust and yield "new policing priorities" (Skogan, 2006, 28–29).

Many police forces combine town hall meetings with **foot patrols** targeting specific beats or communities—a second common COP tactic that allows officers to interact with citizens in more individualized exchanges. Foot patrols have been characterized as a "proactive, non-threatening, community-oriented approach to local policing" (Wakefield, 2007, 343), and are perhaps "the most popular and widely implemented component of community policing" (Rosenbaum and Lurigio, 1994, 303), at least in high-income countries. As Skogan (2006, 39–40) notes, many citizens "value the time officers spend meeting with them, and they like to see officers on foot rather than driving past on the way to a crime scene." Foot patrols serve precisely this purpose.

Even when town hall meetings and foot patrols are not accompanied by deeper institutional or philosophical changes, they can nonetheless constitute a dramatic departure from the status quo, especially in LICs. In many LICs, policing is primarily reactive: police officers respond when a victim of crime requests assistance (if they respond at all), but otherwise do not engage communities in any proactive way, and generally do not seek direct dialogue with citizens outside the context of criminal investigations and arrests. In these settings, town hall meetings and foot patrols represent a marked shift from reactive to proactive policing and—when done well—from adversarial to cooperative relationships with citizens.

The informal, mutually respectful interactions that (ideally) occur during town hall meetings and foot patrols may improve citizens' perceptions of police officers' intentions, capacity, and responsiveness to citizen feedback. These interactions may also foster norms of citizen cooperation with the police and increase citizens' willingness to report crime victimization, crime prevention tips, and cases of police misconduct. Through the information police officers provide during town hall meetings, citizens may also develop greater knowledge of, and trust in, the courts and the criminal justice system, and a better understanding of the resource constraints under which police forces operate, potentially increasing citizen demand for government spending on policing.

Likewise, through their interactions with citizens during town hall meetings and foot patrols, police officers themselves may develop a greater sense of empathy and accountability towards the communities they serve, and a better understanding of the seriousness of police misconduct as an obstacle to police-community relations. They may also become less likely to engage in abuse, bribery, and other forms of

misconduct themselves. Finally, the mere physical presence of police officers during town hall meetings or foot patrols may help reduce crime victimization (MacDonald, 2002) and mitigate citizen perceptions of insecurity.

Third, as part of their community policing initiatives, many police departments enlist citizens in the co-production of public safety through the formation of *neighborhood watch teams* (NWTs), which have become “one of the most known and common tools” of COP (Ekici et al., 2022, 117). NWTs typically serve two purposes: they provide security by, for example, conducting their own patrols to monitor crime and deter potential criminals, and they act as liaisons between communities and the police when crimes are committed or violence occurs. NWTs may also coordinate their efforts with those of other local authorities, who can similarly act as liaisons between citizens and the police.

These initiatives may be especially fruitful in LICs, where police forces are often severely resource constrained. NWTs may deter potential criminals by increasing the probability they will be caught, while also “enhancing police detection” through the provision of information (Bennett, Holloway and Farrington, 2007, 438). Citizens are a crucial source of information about where crime is being committed and who is committing it. While police forces could, in principle, gather this information independently, doing so is challenging, time-consuming, costly, and labor-intensive. NWTs serve to “increase the flow of useful information from the public to the police,” thus helping the police allocate their limited time and resources more efficiently (Bennett et al., 2007, 438–439).

NWTs can thus increase reporting of crime victimization, crime prevention tips, and incidents of police misconduct, both directly to the police and indirectly through local authorities; can facilitate referral of crime victimization cases from local authorities to the police; can promote norms of citizen cooperation with the police; and can improve both objective (crime victimization) and subjective (citizen perceptions of insecurity) indicators of public safety. They can also help build trust between community members themselves, especially among those who participate in NWTs, but also among those who do not participate but who nonetheless acknowledge and appreciate their neighbors’ efforts.

In summary, COP can reduce the perceived costs and increase the perceived benefits of citizen cooperation. It can do so by increasing citizens’ access to the police, improving their understanding of the criminal justice system, mitigating their concerns about the intentions, capacity, and responsiveness of police officers whom they might otherwise perceive as corrupt or biased, and lowering the risk of social sanctions for those who engage with the police. These are generally considered to be the primary goals of COP (Skogan, 2006). Moreover, while crime control was not a “key reason for the adoption of [COP]” in the US or other high-income countries, it nonetheless remains a “desired” secondary goal of COP interventions (Gill et al., 2014, 403). Advocates argue that COP can reduce crime victimization directly through increased police and NWT presence at the beat or neighborhood level, and indirectly through increased citizen cooperation, on which the efficacy of policing arguably depends (Greene and Mastrofski, 1988).

2.2. Community policing in the Global South

Few (if any) other models for improving police-community relations have been as widely embraced as COP, including in LICs. In sub-Saharan Africa—the focus of our study—COP has been adopted in one form or another in the Democratic Republic of Congo (Wisler, Monti-Ohanessian and Coia, 2021), eSwatini (Kyed, 2018), Ghana,⁴ Guinea,⁵ Kenya,⁶ Mozambique (Kyed, 2018), Namibia,⁷ Nigeria (Kpae

and Adishi, 2017), Rwanda,⁸ Sierra Leone (Albrecht, 2015), Somalia (Muibu, 2022), South Africa (Modise, Mugambiwa and Rakubu, 2024), South Sudan,⁹ and Zambia (Musonda, 2019), among other countries. As in Uganda (and, indeed, as in most African contexts), these COP initiatives typically involve the introduction of a relatively narrow set of new policing practices, which are sometimes accompanied by rhetorical shifts towards a community-focused, “service-oriented” concept of policing, but which are seldom grounded in larger structural or philosophical reforms.

COP has been embraced outside of Africa as well, including in Belize,¹⁰ East Timor (De Sousa, Belo and Koenig, 2011), Iraq,¹¹ and Nicaragua (McNeish, Martinez Prado and Frühling Ehrlich, 2019). The US, EU, UN, International Association of Chiefs of Police, and a variety of other donors and international organizations now advocate COP and have incorporated it into their police reform initiatives around the world (National Academies of Sciences, Engineering and Medicine, 2021). Understanding whether these initiatives can succeed despite the operational challenges inherent to policing in LICs is thus a first order concern, with important theoretical and policy implications that scholars have only recently begun to explore.

Indeed, there are reasons to be skeptical of the prospects for COP, especially in LICs. LIC police forces may lack the capacity to implement COP successfully, at least without large, unsustainable infusions of foreign funding. Even when commanding officers are committed to COP, they may struggle to monitor their rank-and-file counterparts, who may revert to more passive (and thus less labor-intensive) forms of policing. Citizens may distrust the police so deeply, or view them as so thoroughly politicized, that they refrain from participating in COP activities altogether. “Mere” tactical changes may be insufficient to overcome profound citizen skepticism of this sort, or to neutralize deeper political grievances that obstruct police-community relations—a possibility we consider in further detail in the conclusion. Meanwhile, COP initiatives continue to proliferate throughout the Global South, in forms that often closely resemble the intervention we evaluate here. As Gill et al. (2014, 405) explain in their systematic review of COP studies in the Global North, their goal is “to evaluate COP as it has come to be understood in practice, rather than the theoretical ideal.” We conduct our evaluation in this same spirit.

2.3. Hypotheses

The challenges of implementing COP in LICs notwithstanding, we were cautiously optimistic that COP in Uganda might have a variety of beneficial effects, especially in rural areas. We pre-registered the following hypotheses about the expected effects of Uganda’s COP program on our primary outcomes:

Security of life and property.

P1a. (–) effect on crime victimization.

P1b. (–) effect on citizen perceptions of insecurity.

Citizen perceptions of the police.

P2. (+) effect on citizen approval of the police.

Police perceptions of and behaviors toward citizens.

P3a. (+) effect on police empathy, accountability, and perceptions of the seriousness of police misconduct.

P3b. (–) effect on police abuse and bribery.

Citizen cooperation with the police.

P4a. (+) effect on reporting of crime victimization.

P4b. (+) effect on reporting of crime prevention tips.

⁸ See the Rwanda National Police’s page on “Policing in the 21st Century.”

⁹ See, for example, the UN Mission in South Sudan’s [community policing training program](#).

¹⁰ See the Belize Police Department’s [page on community policing](#).

¹¹ See the [Community Policing Forums](#) established by the International Organization for Migration in Iraq.

⁴ See the Ghana Police Service’s [Community Policing Unit](#).

⁵ See Guinea’s “Partners for Security” program.

⁶ See the Kenya Police Service’s [page on community policing](#).

⁷ See the Namibian Police Force’s [Safer Namibia Initiative](#).

P4c. (+) effect on reporting of police misconduct.

Demand for government spending on the police.

P5. (+) effect on citizen demand for government spending on the police.

Reporting to and referral from local authorities.¹²

P6a. (+) effect on citizen reporting of crime victimization to local authorities.

P6b. (+) effect on local authority referrals of crime victimization to the police.

We also pre-registered the following hypotheses regarding the program's expected effects on our secondary outcomes:¹³

Perceived costs of citizen cooperation with the police.

S1a. (+) effect on citizen perceptions of police intentions.

S1b. (+) effect on citizen knowledge about the criminal justice system.

S1c. (+) effect on norms of citizen cooperation with the police.

Perceived returns to citizen cooperation with the police.

S2a. (+) effect on citizen beliefs about police capacity.

S2b. (+) effect on citizen perceptions of police responsiveness to citizen feedback.

Trust in the criminal justice system.

S3. (+) effect on trust in the courts.

Trust in other community members.

S4. (+) effect on trust in other community members.

SI Section M provides a mapping between these hypotheses and our outcome measures.

3. Crime and policing in Uganda

Uganda is an instructive setting for studying the effects of COP in a low-income country. Uganda is in the mid-range of the World Bank's ranking of LICs in terms of economic development (as captured by GDP per capita) and human development (as captured by HDI). Electoral authoritarian regimes like Uganda's are common across the Global South, especially in sub-Saharan Africa. As we demonstrate in Fig. 1, the number of police officers per capita in Uganda is near the African median, at least among the 17 African countries for which these data are available, suggesting the UPF is not an outlier in terms of the resources it enjoys. Moreover, while baseline levels of trust in the UPF leave much room for improvement, they too are close to the median among African countries, as Fig. 2 shows. These parallels suggest that lessons learned in Uganda may apply to other African countries and potentially to other LICs.

Outside Kampala, the capital and largest city in Uganda, where the police headquarters are located, the UPF is divided into regional and district units. Each district has a central police station that provides

supervision and resources to sub-district police stations and posts (i.e., beats). Posts are staffed by rank-and-file officers who report to a commander based at a station. A mapping exercise we conducted at baseline found that the average station in our sample supervises 1.3 posts (with a minimum of 0 and a maximum of 8) and covers about 39 villages. The average number of UPF officers deployed to stations and posts is 5 and 3, respectively. Only 10% of police stations receive a monthly fuel allowance; none of the posts do. The average station in our sample has one motorbike; the average post has 0.5. None of the posts or stations has a functioning computer.

Political bias and excessive use of force against citizens strain police-community relations in Uganda (Wagner, Hout and Namara, 2020). While Uganda holds periodic elections, their credibility has deteriorated over time. Since 1986, the same party (the National Resistance Movement, or NRM) and president (Yoweri Museveni) have ruled the country. The NRM undoubtedly enjoys pockets of popular support. However, to retain power, it resorts to politicized prosecutions of opposition leaders and—most relevant for our purposes—intimidation by security forces. The UPF also engages in more routine acts of misconduct. In our baseline survey, a majority (57%) of respondents agreed with the statement that the police are corrupt and are primarily interested in pursuing their “personal interests” rather than serving their communities. In Uganda, as in other African nations, the police also played a lead role in enforcing public health restrictions during the COVID-19 pandemic, in some cases further aggravating police-community tensions (Blair et al., 2022; Grasse et al., 2021).

Meanwhile, crime is common throughout Uganda, including in rural regions.¹⁴ Most of our baseline survey respondents (65.1%) had witnessed or heard about at least one crime in their village in the past six months, and in all 288 villages there was at least one respondent who had witnessed or heard about at least one crime, with an average of 4.1 reports per village. Against this backdrop, COP was first introduced in Uganda in 1989, with the Katwe Police Division and later the Kampala Police Station designated as pilot sites (Kasingye, 2022). The UPF ostensibly expanded COP throughout the country in 1993, 2000, and 2008, but did not introduce formal mechanisms to ensure nationwide implementation, and take-up was inconsistent (Kasingye, 2003; Musime, 2012; Raleigh et al., 1998).

The UPF published a COP strategy report in 2011 (and again in 2017) but did little to implement it beyond the assignment of Community Liaison Officers and the provision of rudimentary training at the district level (Divon, 2020). In a qualitative evaluation conducted in 2013, Irish Aid concluded that “while there is strong political will and leadership by the Inspector General to implement community policing across the [UPF], the UPF has yet to develop a roll-out plan, a re-training program, and a means of monitoring implementation” (Carton et al., 2013, 4). Notwithstanding past haphazard implementation, at the time of our study, interest in COP remained high within the UPF and among other government stakeholders (see also FES, 2020, ch. 3.2), especially the Office of the Prime Minister and the Ministry of Justice. This interest ensured a degree of local ownership and commitment, which is vital for the success of government programs. We provide a more detailed timeline of COP in Uganda in SI Section A.

4. The COP intervention

The intervention we study was designed to expand, learn from, and improve upon previous attempts at COP in the country. In early 2018, the UPF formed a working group to determine what a COP program should entail, given the UPF's organizational structure and resource constraints. The working group, comprised of senior UPF officers and representatives of local civil society groups, consulted academic reviews

¹² In Uganda, like in many LICs, local authorities serve as liaisons between citizens and the police. We therefore test whether COP increases crime reporting not just to the police themselves, but also to local authorities, who are then expected to refer those cases to the police.

¹³ In our PAP we distinguished between mechanisms and secondary outcomes; we ignore that distinction here. Results for all pre-specified hypotheses from sections 3.2 and 3.3 of our PAP are included either in the body of the paper or in the SI. The exceptions are results pertaining to our secondary treatment arm and separate analyses of index sub-components related to violence against women specifically. These analyses yield null results; we omit them for compactness. We also omit results pertaining to the more exploratory hypotheses pre-registered as ancillary in section 3.4 of our PAP. Finally, for compactness we omit some of the pre-specified analyses of heterogeneous treatment effects, which produce almost uniformly null results. All of the above results are available upon request; they merely reinforce our finding that Uganda's COP program had weak or null effects on most of our pre-specified outcomes, and in most of our pre-specified treatment effect heterogeneity analyses as well.

¹⁴ According to the ENACT project, in 2023, Uganda ranked 7th out of 54 African countries in terms of criminal activity. See <https://africa.ocindex.net/>.

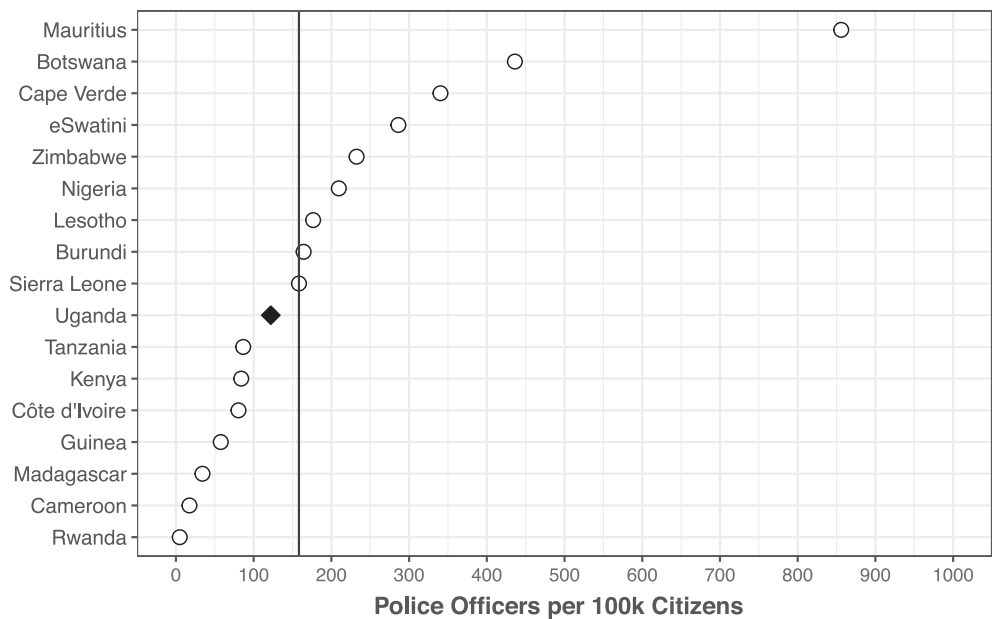


Fig. 1. Police officers per 100,000 citizens across Africa.
Source: UN Office on Drugs and Crime. Vertical line shows the median across countries

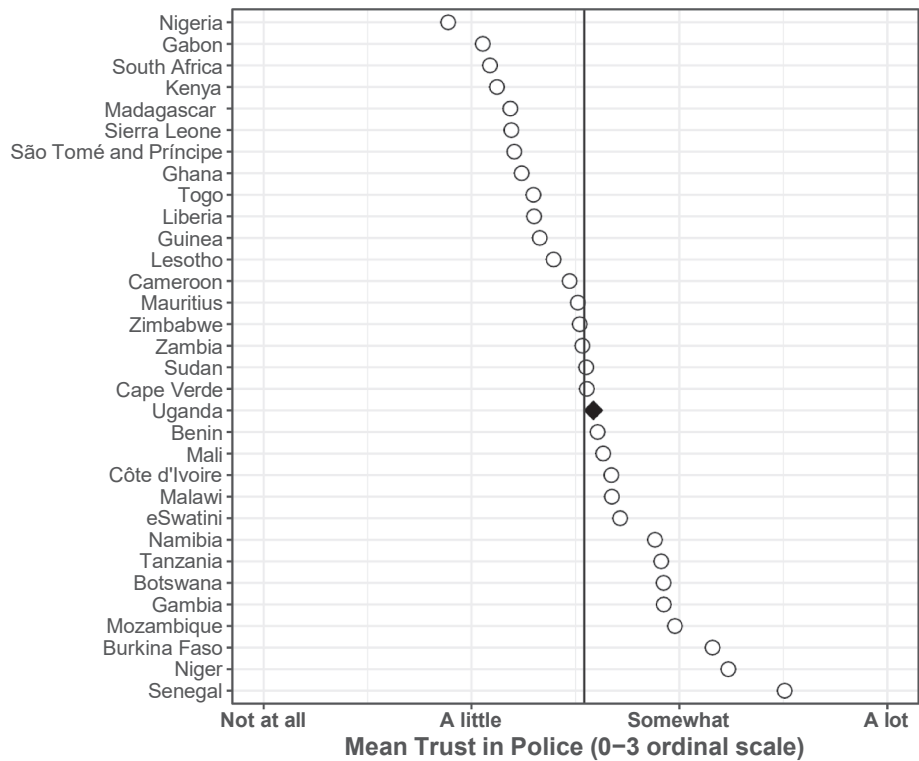


Fig. 2. Trust in the police across Africa.
Source: Afrobarometer round 7. Vertical line shows the median across countries

and white papers on community policing as background to its deliberations. Those efforts resulted in a detailed COP manual specifying requirements and standard operating procedures (SOPs). UPF intentionally designed the SOPs to be realistic, scalable, and sustainable, so that rank-and-file officers would be more likely to comply.

YIDO conducted a series of two-day training sessions for all participating UPF officers to introduce the new COP program and ensure standardized implementation across study sites. The program consisted of three components, all of which are typical of COP interventions

around the world (Ekici et al., 2022):

1. **Town hall meetings** to establish a more constant police presence in communities; educate citizens about police responsibilities and obligations; build rapport between citizens and the UPF; encourage crime reporting to the UPF; and brainstorm local solutions to local problems. UPF's target was for town hall meetings to occur once every two to three months per village. Officers traveled from their

stations or posts to attend the town hall meetings, which were held in a public space in each village. YIDO assisted with logistics.

2. **Foot patrols** to create opportunities for more interpersonal interaction and direct dialogue between individual citizens and UPF officers than would be possible in the context of a town hall meeting. Foot patrols also aimed to reduce crime through the direct deterrent effect of roving police presence, including at night. Officers were also instructed to disseminate information about UPF oversight and accountability mechanisms during foot patrols and town hall meetings. UPF's target was for foot patrols to occur once a month per village.
3. **Formation of neighborhood watch teams (NWTs)** to create cadres of residents who better understand police procedures and resources and who are tasked with monitoring crime, meeting regularly to discuss security concerns, and establishing a more direct line of communication between citizens and the police. Each NWT serves one village, with members selected from among the village's adult residents.¹⁵ Importantly, NWTs were explicitly forbidden to make arrests or adjudicate criminal cases.

The intervention we evaluate thus combines three of the most common elements of COP as it is usually implemented in practice. But as noted above, a wide variety of tactics fall under the rubric of COP. Our evaluation does not address these other tactics, and we cannot be sure how effective they would have been in Uganda. Nor can we be sure how effective each element of the "bundle" we evaluate would have been in isolation. Moreover, as we show below, Uganda's COP intervention increased exposure to town hall meetings and NWTs among randomly selected residents, but did not increase their awareness of foot (or vehicular) patrols. This is a hard test for treatment compliance, as foot patrols were intended to provide more intensive interactions between UPF officers and a relatively small subset of residents, thus mechanically lowering the probability that a randomly selected resident would have been exposed to them. (As we discuss below, UPF logs suggest that officers typically interacted with fewer than 15 residents per foot patrol.) In addition, as we discuss in SI Section F.5, patrols often occurred at night, when most residents likely would not have been awake to witness them. Nonetheless, our results should be interpreted with these caveats in mind.

5. Research design

5.1. Sampling frame

YIDO trained UPF officers on the SOPs described above in 13 districts across Uganda,¹⁶ which UPF chose for inclusion in the study using two selection criteria: equal representation of Uganda's four regions and, within each region, relatively high crime rates. Given the UPF's resource constraints, we considered it unlikely that COP would be effective in urban locations; many criminologists similarly believe that COP "can be effective in rural areas but not in urban settings" (Ekici et al., 2022, 113). We also expected that UPF officers would be less politicized in rural areas. We therefore excluded central stations located in district capitals and stations covering parishes with populations greater than 90,000. In addition, we excluded police posts with peculiar jurisdictions, such as those protecting hospitals or bus stations. Finally, we excluded posts that had only one officer assigned to them.

We then randomly selected one post per station. In places where the station had only one post, we selected that one (18 stations); in areas

with no posts (smaller jurisdictions that do not require any posts), we selected the station (32 stations). The result was a sample of 72 relatively rural, high-crime police posts and stations spanning four regions. For compactness, we refer to these 72 posts and stations simply as "police stations" from here on.

5.2. Randomization

Our unit of randomization is the police station. We organized police stations into blocks of four and randomly assigned two stations per block to treatment. We formed blocks within each of Uganda's four regions by minimizing the within-block Mahalanobis distance between baseline covariates.¹⁷ We report balance tests in SI Section C and descriptive statistics in SI Section D.

5.3. Data and measurement

Administrative data: We measured crime as reported to the UPF using administrative data. Before the intervention began, we collected baseline data on all crimes reported to all UPF stations in our sample from March 1 to May 27, 2018. We collected the same data at endline from July 15, 2019, to January 15, 2020.¹⁸ We use these data to construct an index, *Crime Admin*, measured at both baseline and endline. For each police station, we first count the number of violent and non-violent crimes recorded in the observation period. (See SI Section M for the crime categories classified as violent and non-violent.) We then standardize each crime count using the baseline mean and standard deviation and compute the index as the average of the two standardized measures. The fact that the baseline and endline observation periods differ in length does not threaten causal identification, as our treatment effect estimates are based on cross-sectional comparisons across treatment and control stations at endline rather than over-time comparisons between baseline and endline. We control for the baseline *Crime Admin* index solely to improve statistical precision.

We also collected administrative data on incidents of police misconduct reported to the UPF. We code a simple binary indicator that takes the value 1 if district-level police reported that they had received complaints about officers from a given station, or if there was a station-level record of police misbehavior at that station. This indicator forms part of the index *Report Abuse* that also includes measures from the citizen survey. See SI Section M for details. We discuss potential measurement error in the UPF data below and in SI Section F.4.

Citizen survey: For each police station in our sample, we identified four villages for subsequent survey data collection. We asked the UPF to provide a list of villages (1) located in the same parish as the station and (2) under the jurisdiction of the corresponding station. We selected four villages from each of these station-level lists; to maximize the representativeness of our sample, we selected the four villages at random. In parishes with fewer than four villages, we selected the closest village from an adjacent parish that still fell under the jurisdiction of the same station. The result was a sample of 288 villages. Given that each village falls under the jurisdiction of just one station, those that fall under the

¹⁵ Selection processes vary from village to village. Typically, the LC1 chairperson and other village leaders nominated some members; the residents of each neighborhood nominated others.

¹⁶ Mbarara, Lira, Mbale, Gulu, Mityana, Kamuli, Jinja, Tororo, Iganga, Kabale, Rakai, Arua, and Ntungamo.

¹⁷ We used the 2014 census to construct 11 blocking variables at the station level: population; % male; average age; % literate; average household size; average years of education; average number of meals eaten per day; % involved in an occupation other than subsistence agriculture; a standardized household asset index; a standardized household quality index; and a standardized index of social services available. We also constructed six additional blocking variables for the number of posts, parishes, villages, and police officers under the station's jurisdiction as well as the distance to Kampala and the district capital.

¹⁸ Endline data collection in four police stations took place in December 2019, while data collection in all remaining stations occurred in February 2020. For the first four stations, administrative records cover the period from June 1 to December 1, 2019. Endline measures for all stations are thus based on a comparable six-month observation window.

jurisdiction of a treatment station were, in effect, assigned to treatment as well; UPF officers were expected to hold town hall meetings, conduct foot patrols, and organize NWTs in these villages.¹⁹ Villages that fall under the jurisdiction of a control station were, in effect, assigned to control.

We conducted baseline and endline surveys with community residents, administered in person by local enumerators from IPA Uganda.²⁰ The baseline took place between June and July 2018. We randomly selected 12 households in each village in our sample from a roster of all households. To ensure gender balance, we sampled six men and six women per village; only female enumerators interviewed female respondents. We replaced households where randomly selected respondents could not be surveyed on the enumeration day. The result was a stratified random sample of 3,456 respondents.

The endline survey took place in December 2019 and January 2020. Wherever possible, we interviewed the same respondents at endline, replacing them only when they were unavailable, had died, or had moved away. In total, we replaced 510 out of 3,456 citizen respondents for an attrition rate of about 15%. Reassuringly, as we show in Tables SI-4 and SI-5, we find no evidence of differential rates or patterns of attrition across treatment groups. The estimation section below explains how we address missing baseline covariates for replacement respondents. SI Section L shows that all results are robust to excluding these observations.

Village leader survey: Especially in LICs, police forces do not operate in isolation from other local actors. In Uganda, each village local council (LC1) has a chairperson who regularly convenes community meetings and serves as a liaison between the community and the police. We measure the attitudes of local authorities using a survey of LC1 chairpeople at endline. We managed to interview the LC1 chairperson in each of our 288 study villages—a response rate of 100%. We administered the LC1 survey concurrently with the citizen survey.

Police officer survey: We measured UPF officers' attitudes and behaviors using baseline and endline surveys. The baseline took place between June and July 2018. In each of the 72 police stations in our sample, we interviewed the Officer in Charge and, whenever possible, the Community Liaison Officer and the Child and Family Protection Unit officer. Among the more junior officers, we randomly selected as many as needed to reach a quota of 5 respondents per station, for a total of 217 officers. We sought to interview the same officers at endline, though by that point many had been reassigned to different locations or were otherwise unavailable. Among the 198 officers we interviewed at endline, only 44 were also interviewed at baseline. The rest were randomly selected replacement officers. In Tables SI-4 and SI-5, we again show that attrition is not correlated with treatment assignment. Nonetheless, our treatment effect estimates reflect outcomes among the officers surveyed at endline, who in many cases were not the same as those surveyed at baseline. We thus cannot distinguish between effects on the behavior of existing officers and changes in officer composition.

Using these data sources, we construct outcomes as follows. Each measure is standardized by subtracting the baseline mean and dividing by the baseline standard deviation where available; otherwise, we use the control group mean and standard deviation. To form indices, we impute missing values separately within treatment and control groups using linear models that regress each item on the remaining index components and block fixed effects. We then average the items and restandardize the resulting index. This procedure ensures a common estimation sample and exploits correlations among items within an

index. SI Section K shows that our results are robust to alternative index construction methods, including a simple average without imputation and an inverse-covariance weighted index (Anderson, 2008). Table SI-39 demonstrates that indices constructed using different methods are highly correlated. Analyses of individual outcomes use listwise deletion. SI Section M details the question wording and coding of all measures and links them to our pre-registered hypotheses.

5.4. Ethics

We sought to anticipate and mitigate potential ethical concerns arising from Uganda's COP program and our evaluation of it. We describe the safeguards we adopted briefly here, and in further detail in SI Section B. First, we successfully encouraged the UPF to implement the intervention at a time (between general elections) and in places (in rural rather than urban areas) where politicization of policing is less common. Second, to mitigate the risk of abuses by the UPF during the program itself, we excluded specialized, quasi-militarized units from the intervention and developed a robust monitoring and reporting system that allowed us to observe many (though not all) of the interactions between citizens and police officers that occurred in the context of implementation. (As we show below, we observe a substantively small, statistically unstable increase in "informal payments" to the UPF in treatment villages, but otherwise we are not aware of any serious adverse events that occurred at any point during implementation.)

Third, to minimize the risk of vigilantism by NWTs, YIDO and UPF repeatedly emphasized that NWTs have no legal authority to arrest, adjudicate crimes, or otherwise act as substitutes for the police. Fourth, to maximize respondents' confidentiality and autonomy during survey data collection, all surveys were administered in private and respondents were repeatedly reminded of their ability to skip any question or module of the survey, or to discontinue their participation altogether. Finally, to safeguard respondent privacy, we exclude not only direct identifiers (such as names and contact information) but also all geographic details (such as village names and locations) below the district level from the publicly available replication data. We also exclude professional details such as police officers' positions, years of service, and ranks.²¹

5.5. Estimation

We estimate the sample intent-to-treat effect (ITT) of the COP program using an OLS regression of the form

$$y = \alpha + \tau z + X\beta + B\gamma + \varepsilon,$$

where y denotes a vector of outcomes, α is an intercept, τ denotes the sample ITT, z is a vector of treatment assignment indicators at the community level, X is a matrix of covariates with associated coefficient vector β , B is a matrix of block fixed effects with associated coefficient vector γ , and ε is a vector of error terms. The covariate matrix X includes a baseline measure of the outcome where available and an indicator for missing values in the baseline measure, which have been imputed as zeros. Baseline covariates are mechanically missing for replacement respondents, who were not interviewed at baseline. Imputing zeros and including a missingness indicator could therefore introduce post-treatment bias if the treatment affected which respondents were replaced and by whom. However, SI Section F.2 shows no evidence of treatment effects on attrition rates or patterns, and the sampling strategy for originally sampled and replacement respondents was identical. Moreover, our results are robust to excluding replacement respondents altogether (see SI Section L).

¹⁹ For each of the 36 treatment group stations, we also randomly selected two of the four study villages under the station's jurisdiction to receive additional training and resources for NWTs. All analyses in this paper marginalize over this secondary treatment arm. (We find no evidence that the secondary treatment arm affected our outcomes of interest).

²⁰ Survey instruments are available in our replication files.

²¹ See the de-identification scripts in our public replication repository for further details on the information excluded from the datasets.

For analyses based on surveys of citizens, local leaders, or police officers, the unit of analysis is the respondent, and we cluster our standard errors at the police station level. For analyses based on administrative data, the unit of analysis is the police station, and standard errors are heteroskedasticity robust. Following our PAP, we use the Benjamini-Hochberg correction to adjust for multiple comparisons across our primary hypotheses. Exploratory analyses of heterogeneous treatment effects do not adjust for multiple comparisons.

6. Results

6.1. First stage

Implementation challenges are endemic to COP. As Mastrofski, Willis and Kochel (2007, 224–226) observe, even in the US, where police forces are (relatively) resource-rich, “police generally regard community policing as time consuming and labor intensive,” and many have “found the implementation of community policing demanding.” The challenges are myriad: rank-and-file officers may resist adopting tactics they perceive to be akin to public relations or social work; commanding officers may struggle to coordinate and prioritize community and “traditional” (reactive) policing practices; and police departments as a whole may fail to muster the resources to implement COP effectively. In their systematic review of COP research, Gill et al. (2014, 411) note that some studies found “no evidence the police actually carried out the planned activities.” If implementation challenges and difficulties of command and control are pervasive in high-income countries like the US, they are likely to be even more so in LICs (Blair et al., 2024).

Uganda’s COP program was by no means immune from these problems, as we discuss below and in SI Section F.5. But challenges notwithstanding, we find that the program was successful in increasing both the frequency of police-community interactions (primarily via town hall meetings) and the degree of community involvement in policing via NWTs (Table 1). For example, 28% of respondents in villages that fall within the jurisdiction of a treatment station (i.e., treatment villages) recalled a town hall meeting with UPF at baseline; this share increased to 45% at endline. In control villages, the share was 30% at both baseline and endline. (Based on focus groups conducted before the start of the intervention, we suspect that most meetings in control villages were informal and not focused on COP, though we cannot be sure.) Similarly, residents of treatment villages were more likely to report the existence of a NWT in their village, and more likely to report that the NWT actively conducts patrols. (Note, again, that our intervention focuses on town hall meetings, NWTs, and patrols, and does not address other COP tactics.)

We find no evidence, however, that residents of treatment villages were more likely to have witnessed UPF officers conducting foot patrols in their communities. This could be because fewer citizens interacted with officers during foot patrols (thereby reducing the probability that a randomly sampled resident would have observed one), or because UPF officers were more diligent in organizing town hall meetings and NWTs than they were in conducting foot patrols. Below and in SI Section F.5 we also present evidence that the UPF was more likely to patrol treatment villages at night, when many residents may have been asleep. (Given capacity constraints, the UPF unfortunately does not maintain detailed records of the dates and locations of its foot patrols—though, as we discuss below, YIDO and IPA documented the proceedings at many town hall meetings. We describe the various other sources of data we collected to monitor treatment compliance in SI Section F.5.)

Following our PAP, we combine these measures into an aggregate index of treatment compliance in Table 1, column 6. The *F*-statistic from a regression of the index on treatment assignment is 20.84, indicating a significant “first stage” relationship between treatment assignment and exposure to COP. Note that this is a hard test for compliance, since our aggregate index relies on the self-reports of randomly sampled survey respondents, some of whom may not have been aware of the COP

activities occurring in their villages. (To address this possibility, we examine the effects of the program among village leaders below. Village leaders were directly involved in the planning and execution of COP activities.)

Field reports compiled by YIDO and IPA suggest that, at least in the case of town hall meetings, Uganda’s COP program induced meaningful interpersonal interactions between citizens and UPF officers, and involved both citizens and officers in identifying local solutions to local problems. At least 352 town hall meetings were held as part of the program between June 2018 and November 2019. (More town hall meetings may have occurred without YIDO’s or IPA’s knowledge. Indeed, as we discuss in SI Section F.5, UPF recorded 427 town hall meetings in treatment villages during the evaluation period.) The number of attendees at these meetings ranged from a low of five to a high of 224. The LC1 chairperson was present at almost all meetings; women’s group and youth group representatives were present at 41% and 25% of all meetings, respectively.

Topics of discussion ranged widely, with the most common issues related to the formation and functioning of NWTs, discussed in over half of all meetings. Other discussion topics were variable and sometimes only indirectly associated with crime: truancy and the need to educate local youths (discussed in roughly one-third of all meetings); drug and alcohol abuse (nearly one-quarter of all meetings); health and sanitation (roughly one-fifth); domestic abuse and sexual and gender-based violence (roughly one-fifth); and gambling (roughly one-seventh), among others. This is typical of COP, which is designed to involve police officers in the more quotidian challenges facing communities, drawing on citizens’ knowledge to identify and address “the social issues that create crime, disorder, and fear” (Gill et al., 2014, 401). In many cases, the officers and attendees proposed new village policies on the spot to address complaints about these and other issues.²²

Our treatment compliance data for NWTs and foot patrols are not as informative, as we were not able to observe these components of the intervention first hand. With this caveat, we confirmed the existence of NWTs in 114 of 144 treatment villages through phone calls with LC1 chairpeople and NWT leaders in December 2018. Based on subsequent phone calls with LC1 chairpeople, we believe NWTs were eventually formed in most of the remaining treatment villages as well. Rosters of NWT participants collected from a subset of treatment villages suggest membership typically ranged from 10 to 30 residents per village. Larger NWTs were often subdivided into smaller “cells,” each with its own leadership structure typically comprising a chairperson, secretary, and head of security. Most LC1 chairpeople in control villages reported the existence of NWTs as well, though in many cases we believe they were referring to more informal groupings of residents, or to the LC1 council itself. (We asked whether residents were “organized into groups to ensure security in the area”—a function that many LC1 councils play.)

Most LC1 chairpeople in both treatment and control villages also reported foot patrols by UPF officers. While LC1 chairpeople in treatment villages were no more likely than their control village counterparts to report foot patrols during the day, they were nine percentage points more likely to report nighttime foot patrols. This may help explain our finding in Table 1 that treatment village residents were no more likely than residents of control villages to report exposure to foot patrols, as residents may not have been awake to witness foot patrols conducted at night. UPF logs from the first month of the intervention suggest that officers generally interacted with no more than 15 residents per foot patrol, and often interacted with fewer. This too may help explain our findings in Table 1. (Note, again, that interactions during foot patrols were more limited in scope by design.) We discuss these and other data

²² For example, in one village, attendees agreed that bars should close by 10:00 pm to reduce public drunkenness and petty theft. In another, attendees agreed to a new garbage disposal regimen to prevent the spread of diseases during the rainy season. These are two examples among many.

Table 1
Compliance with COP program.

	Foot Patrols	Vehicle Patrols	Community Meeting	Existence NWT	NWT Patrols	Compliance Index
COP	−0.039 (0.069)	0.056 (0.061)	0.311*** (0.070)	0.203*** (0.076)	0.180** (0.083)	0.151*** (0.046)
Control mean	0.22	0.03	0.04	0.63	0.6	0.3
Control sd	1.21	1.03	1.02	1.37	1.54	0.84
Num. obs.	3452	3451	3451	3418	3378	3456
N Clusters	72	72	72	72	72	72

*** $p < 0.01$; ** $p < 0.05$; * $p < 0.1$.

Note: Outcomes are standardized using baseline means and standard deviations. Analyses in columns 1–5 rely on listwise deletion. The index in column 6 is constructed by imputing missing values and averaging the other five measures, then re-standardizing the index using the mean and standard deviation of the corresponding baseline index. Numbers in parentheses are standard errors that allow for clustering by police stations. Significance stars are based on p -values for two-tailed tests that have *not* been corrected for multiple comparisons, as pre-registered. All measures are taken from the citizen survey. All analyses include block fixed effects and control for the baseline outcome measure. We replace missing values in baseline covariates with zeros and control for an indicator for missingness in these covariates. See SI Section M for outcome question wording and coding.

sources on treatment compliance in further detail in SI Section F.5.

6.2. Effects on main and secondary outcomes

We next estimate whether the increase in police-community interactions and citizen involvement in policing, reported in Table 1, was sufficient to affect our primary outcomes of interest. As shown in Table 2, we find no evidence that the COP program reduced the prevalence of crime as measured in our survey (P1a). This result is robust to aggregating multiple types of crime into a single index, distinguishing between violent and non-violent crime, and disaggregating crime by type.²³ The result also holds for property destruction and violent disputes over land use or boundaries.

At baseline, approximately 24% of respondents reported being worried or very worried that they or a household member would become a victim of violent crime in the coming year (Table SI-2). We find no evidence that the COP program improved this or related perceptions of security (P1b). This null result holds both for the index and for each of its individual components. Nor do we find evidence that the COP program improved perceptions of the police (P2). Roughly 59% of respondents reported being satisfied with police services in their community at baseline, and about 62% agreed that they generally trust the police. At the same time, 44% said they would feel intimidated if they encountered an officer in their community (Table SI-2). At endline, residents of treatment communities were no more likely to express trust in or satisfaction with the police and no less likely to feel intimidated by the police than those in control communities.

Furthermore, we do not find evidence that the program improved empathy, accountability, or perceptions of the seriousness of police misconduct among police officers (P3a). Perhaps relatedly, we find some evidence that the program increased police abuse and bribery (P3b), a result driven by a slight increase in the reported frequency with which respondents made “informal payments” to the police, though this result is no longer statistically significant at conventional levels after correcting for multiple comparisons.

Baseline responses reveal variation in support for police intervention across crime categories (see Table SI-2). While only 32% of respondents said they would want police or courts to intervene in a hypothetical incident of domestic violence, 64% of respondents supported intervention in the case of burglary and 87% in an armed robbery. However, reporting of actual crime prevention tips to assist police intervention was rare at baseline: only 13% of respondents said they had provided information to support a police investigation in the last six months, and 15% said they had reported suspicious activity.

We do not find evidence that the intervention affected any of these outcomes. We find no evidence that the program strengthened citizens’ preferences for police intervention in hypothetical crime scenarios, or that it increased reporting of actual crimes by victims or witnesses as measured in our survey (P4a). Nor do we find evidence that the program increased the reporting of crime prevention tips to the police (P4b). We do find suggestive evidence of increased reporting of police misconduct (P4c), a result driven by an increase in citizen complaints in the UPF’s records. While this result is consistent with the apparent increase in informal payments to the UPF, it is not statistically significant after a multiple comparisons correction. Unsurprisingly, given the null effects on crime, citizens’ perceptions of safety, and citizens’ attitudes toward the police, we find no evidence of an increase in citizens’ demand for more government spending on policing (P5).

In rural Uganda, the nearest police station could be many kilometers away, and many citizens cannot contact the police by phone. In such a setting, villagers could have reported crimes and crime prevention tips to the UPF *indirectly*, by reporting to other local authorities (e.g., LC1s) in the expectation that these reports would eventually be referred to the police. We explore this possibility using our LC1s survey. We do not find evidence that the program affected village leaders’ expectations that citizens would report crimes to them (P6a), nor did it affect the willingness of village leaders to refer cases to the police (P6b).

Our results in Table 2 suggest that the UPF’s efforts to create a homegrown, scalable, and sustainable COP program did not affect most (if any) of our primary outcomes. Table 3 suggests that the COP program did not affect most of our secondary outcomes either. We find no evidence that the program improved citizens’ perceptions of the UPF’s intentions (S1a), their understanding of Uganda’s criminal justice system (S1b), or norms of citizen cooperation with the police (S1c). Nor do we find evidence that the program enhanced citizens’ beliefs about the UPF’s capacity (S2a) or its responsiveness to citizens (S2b). Finally, we find no evidence that the program increased trust in the courts (S3) or other community members (S4). These results are robust to removing baseline covariates and to excluding 510 replacement respondents, whom we only interviewed at endline (see SI Section L).

The only outcome for which we find evidence of a treatment effect is the prevalence of crime as measured through administrative data. If anything, the program appears to have *increased* the number of crimes recorded by the UPF. This finding is difficult to interpret. Because most crimes in rural Uganda go unreported, the increase in crime in UPF’s administrative records could reflect greater reporting rather than higher incidence. However, we find no corresponding increase in self-reported crime reporting in our citizen survey (Table 2). This pattern—an increase in crime in UPF administrative data but no evidence of increased crime reporting in the survey—remains robust to alternative codings, including an analysis of station-level crime reporting rates measured using our survey data (Table SI-14).

²³ Disaggregated results are not reported for compactness but are available upon request.

Table 2
ITT on primary outcomes.

	Crime Victimization	Perceived Insecurity	Approval Police	Police Empathy	Police Abuse	Report Crime
COP	−0.003 (0.026)	0.017 (0.037)	0.004 (0.036)	−0.109 (0.080)	0.075 (0.036)	−0.011 (0.018)
Control mean	0	−0.08	0.13	0.18	−0.04	0.01
Control sd	0.53	0.63	0.76	0.51	0.62	0.32
Sample	C	C	C	O	C	C
Num. obs.	3456	3456	3456	198	3456	3456
N Clusters	72	72	72	72	72	72
	Report Tips	Report Abuse	Demand Spending	Report to LC1	Referral by LC1	
COP	0.010 (0.022)	0.223 (0.106)	0.024 (0.037)	−0.003 (0.094)	0.158 (0.115)	
Control mean	0.01	0.06	0	0	0	
Control sd	0.6	0.55	1	1	1	
Sample	C	C/A	C	LC1	LC1	
Num. obs.	3456	3456	3456	288	288	
N Clusters	72	72	72	72	72	

*** $p < 0.01$; ** $p < 0.05$; * $p < 0.1$.

Note: Except for “Demand Spending,” outcomes are indices of several items. Outcomes are standardized using, where available, baseline means and standard deviations, and otherwise, control group means and standard deviations. Indices are created by imputing and averaging across individual items and re-standardizing the resulting index. Numbers in parentheses are standard errors that allow for clustering by police stations. Significance stars are based on p -values that have been corrected for all comparisons shown in this table. The row “Sample” indicates whether measures stem from the citizen (C), officer (O), or leader surveys (LC1), or from administrative data (A). Analyses include block fixed effects. Where available, we control for a baseline measure of the outcome. Missing values in baseline covariates have been replaced with zeros and we control for an indicator for missingness in these covariates. See SI Section M for outcome question wording and coding.

Table 3
ITT on secondary outcomes.

	Crime Admin	Police Intentions	Citizen Knowledge	Cooperation Norms	Police Capacity	Police Responsiveness	Trust Courts	Trust Community
COP	0.513* (0.257)	0.007 (0.026)	0.008 (0.012)	−0.032 (0.022)	−0.019 (0.024)	0.028 (0.041)	−0.021 (0.043)	0.019 (0.038)
Control mean	1.04	0	−0.06	−0.07	0.15	0.22	0	0.07
Control sd	1.62	0.5	0.31	0.56	0.64	0.84	1	0.85
Sample	A	C	C	C	C	C	C	C
Num. obs.	72	3456	3456	3456	3456	3456	3456	3455
N Clusters	72	72	72	72	72	72	72	72

*** $p < 0.01$; ** $p < 0.05$; * $p < 0.1$.

Note: Except for “Trust Community,” outcomes are indices of several items. Outcomes are standardized using, where available, baseline means and standard deviations, and otherwise, control group means and standard deviations. Indices are created by imputing and averaging across individual items and re-standardizing the resulting index. The number of observations is smaller in column 8 because we do not impute individual outcomes. Numbers in parentheses are standard errors that allow for clustering by police station. The unit of analysis in column 1 is the police station; hence, we only use heteroskedasticity robust standard errors. Significance stars are based on p -values that have been corrected for all comparisons shown in this table. The row “Sample” indicates whether measures stem from the citizen survey (C), or from administrative data (A). Analyses include block fixed effects. Where available, we control for a baseline measure of the outcome. Missing values in baseline covariates have been replaced with zeros and we control for an indicator for missingness in these covariates. See SI Section M for outcome question wording and coding.

Several explanations are possible. The result may reflect a statistical fluke or an artifact. For example, treated officers may have recorded crimes more diligently to signal performance to superiors who were aware of the intervention. Alternatively, administrative data may capture genuine changes in crime reporting that our survey fails to detect, since UPF’s records cover all crimes within a station’s jurisdiction, whereas our survey measures capture crime reporting behavior only among sampled respondents. Consistent with this interpretation, we show in SI Section F.4 that administrative crime measures correlate more strongly with survey-based measures of crime reporting than with survey-based measures of crime incidence. At the same time, the effect is only marginally statistically significant, runs counter to our otherwise null findings, and concerns an outcome that was pre-registered as secondary. We therefore refrain from drawing strong conclusions from this result.

To aid interpretation of our (generally) null ITT estimates, we report confidence-interval bounds for several core outcomes. For crime victimization, the estimated ITT is close to zero ($\hat{\beta} = -0.003$, s.e. = 0.026), implying a 95% confidence interval of approximately [−0.054,

0.048] standard deviations. For perceived insecurity, the corresponding interval is [−0.056, 0.090] ($\hat{\beta} = 0.017$, s.e. = 0.037), and for approval of the police it is [−0.067, 0.075] ($\hat{\beta} = 0.004$, s.e. = 0.036). These bounds indicate that, while very small changes remain possible, our results are precise enough to rule out meaningful improvements in some of our most central outcomes. We address questions of statistical power in further detail below.

7. Potential explanations for null results

We find little to no evidence that Uganda’s COP program achieved its intended goals.²⁴ While the intervention did increase the frequency of contact between citizens and the UPF (in particular through town hall meetings) and the degree of citizen involvement in crime control and

²⁴ A qualitative assessment of community policing in Gulu, Uganda’s third largest city, similarly finds that the program did not meet its objectives (Divon, 2020).

prevention (primarily through NWTs), our results suggest that these changes did not result in a reduction in crime, an improvement in citizens' perceptions of the police, or changes in most of our other outcomes. What explains these disappointing results, and what could they teach us about the prospects for COP in Uganda and other LICs?

In this section we explore a variety of potential explanations for our findings, drawing both on our survey and on a set of 12 focus group discussions (FGDs) that we conducted with 72 rural Ugandans from four of the villages in our sample—two treatment, two control. Because we only conducted FGDs in four villages, we do not use them for purposes of inference; rather, we draw on them to help contextualize our quantitative results and motivate some of our more formal heterogeneous treatment effect analyses. We describe the design of the FGDs in further detail in SI Section E.

7.1. Flawed research design?

We begin by considering the possibility that our findings are artifacts of flaws in our research design. We address four potential problems in particular: (1) low statistical power, (2) attrition correlated with treatment assignment, (3) spillover, and (4) measurement error. None of these explanations seems especially plausible in our case. As we show in SI Section F.1, our study is sufficiently powered to detect even relatively small treatment effects on our primary outcomes.²⁵ For our core primary outcomes—for example, crime victimization, perceived insecurity, and approval of the police—the implied minimum detectable effects correspond to substantively modest changes in natural units,²⁶ and the confidence intervals exclude effects corresponding to large improvements on the underlying survey scales. These bounds suggest that our null findings are unlikely to be driven by insufficient statistical power to detect substantively meaningful effects. We further demonstrate in SI Section F.2 that while we observe some attrition between baseline and endline (especially in our survey of UPF officers), attrition is not affected by treatment status.

In SI Section F.3, we explore the potential for spillover effects by analyzing secular trends in some of our primary outcomes between baseline and endline among control group stations, and by estimating a model of spatial spillover. (Some spillover analyses were not pre-specified and should be interpreted as exploratory.) We find little to no evidence to suggest that the existence of spillovers drives the apparent absence of treatment effects. Intuitively, the risk of spillover in our study is small. Because we randomized at the station level, and because most stations have jurisdiction over an entire parish or sub-county, treatment and control communities are almost always located in different parishes. Indeed, in seven of the 13 districts in our study, all sample villages in the district were assigned *either* to treatment *or* to control. Even in the remaining districts, our sample consists of police stations and villages that are relatively far apart. The average distance between control stations and the nearest treatment station in our sample is 16 km; the average distance between control villages and the nearest treatment village is 14.2 km. These are long distances in rural Uganda, where roads are rough and most citizens cannot access a vehicle.

Finally, in SI Section F.4, we discuss the potential for measurement error with a particular focus on our measures of crime and crime reporting. We leverage the fact that we use multiple measurement strategies to show that cross-measure correlations follow intuitive patterns and are relatively high, bolstering trust in our measures. We also

show that our results are robust to alternative codings of our crime and reporting measures.

7.2. Demand-side explanations

Next, we consider several potential “demand-side” impediments to COP that originate with citizens' attitudes, behaviors, and demographics. Note that these analyses were not pre-specified and should be interpreted as exploratory attempts to understand the results of the pre-registered analyses above. Moreover, tests for interaction effects are less well-powered than estimates of average treatment effects, and a failure to detect statistically significant heterogeneity does not necessarily imply that moderating factors are absent. The moderators we examine are also imperfect proxies for the underlying mechanisms of interest, and unobserved features of communities or police stations may condition program effectiveness in ways we cannot measure. With these caveats in mind, we examine whether observable demand-side characteristics are associated with substantively larger or smaller treatment effects.

First, some citizens could be so intimidated by the UPF that they were unwilling to interact (much less cooperate) with UPF officers even in the context of a COP program, thus weakening the program's effectiveness (see, for example, Musiime, 2012, 107). In our FGDs, multiple participants described fear as an obstacle to police-community relations in their villages, either because the police “are armed, they can beat you,”²⁷ or, more commonly, because “they can arrest you without doing anything bad.”²⁸ As one respondent pointedly explained, “if you tell me now that police have come, what I do is to hide because they're bad, I know they're going to arrest us.”²⁹

But other FGD respondents in both treatment and control villages insisted that neither they nor their neighbors fear the police, either because “we are friends”³⁰ or, in at least one case, because “people are used to the police, they take them to be weak.”³¹ Testing this explanation more formally, we show in Table SI-22 that respondents who reported feeling intimidated by the police at baseline were *more* likely to report exposure to the UPF in villages assigned to the program. However, we find no evidence that the program had weaker (or stronger) effects on attitudes towards the UPF or cooperation with UPF officers among this subgroup of respondents.

Second, it is possible that some citizens were already satisfied with the UPF's status quo approach to policing, such that any potential improvements in their perceptions of the police (and other outcomes) were subject to ceiling effects (Hanson et al., 2025). Many FGD participants in both treatment and control villages expressed positive views of the UPF, praising them for assisting the LC1 committees, for deterring criminals effectively, and for investigating crimes efficiently. Indeed, in three of the twelve FGDs,³² opinions of the police were so favorable that respondents could not think of any criticisms even when prompted to do so.

As we show in Table SI-23, however, ceiling effects do not appear to explain our findings: we find no evidence that the program was more impactful among respondents who reported lower satisfaction levels at baseline. Nor, for that matter, do we find evidence that ceiling effects more generally help explain our disappointing results: in Table SI-24, we demonstrate that the program was no more or less effective among respondents with high baseline values on each of our primary outcomes. In the FGDs as well, many respondents in both treatment and control

²⁵ Our study is well-powered in part because, for the individual-level outcomes in our data, the intra-cluster correlations (ICCs) range from a low of 0.003 to a high of 0.12; for all but three of these outcomes, the ICCs are below 0.1.

²⁶ Using the rule-of-thumb $MDE = 2.8 \times SE$, our design is powered to detect effects as small as 0.073 on our crime victimization index (≈ 0.14 SD), 0.104 on perceived insecurity (≈ 0.16 SD), and 0.101 on approval of police (≈ 0.13 SD).

²⁷ C4101982983, women, February 15, 2019.

²⁸ T4102033043, men, February 14, 2019.

²⁹ T4102033043, men, February 14, 2019.

³⁰ T4102033043, women, February 14, 2019.

³¹ T2032383841, women, February 15, 2019.

³² C2032333822, women, February 14, 2019; T2032383841, leaders, February 15, 2019; T4102033043, leaders, February 14, 2019.

communities expressed a variety of frustrations with the UPF, especially related to corruption, slow response times, and wrongful arrests. Respondents complained that “we have never been happy with police;”³³ that “no one has gone to the police without complaining about them;”³⁴ or simply that “the police are not good.”³⁵ It seems unlikely that citizens were so enamored with the UPF at baseline that their attitudes could not be improved any further.

Third, it is possible that while the program generally failed to achieve its intended goals, it was more successful among specific subgroups that were more likely to benefit from increased police presence in their communities. Previous studies have suggested, for example, that women are disadvantaged under the local, informal mechanisms of dispute resolution that pervade many African countries, especially in rural areas (Blair et al., 2019; Chopra and Isser, 2012). COP may be more effective among women, who, theory suggests, would disproportionately benefit from greater access to and closer coordination with the police, especially to address domestic violence and other gendered crimes. Our FGDs support this theoretical intuition: many male respondents complained that “domestic violence is not supposed to go to the government,”³⁶ and that while “our great grandfathers used to tell us beating woman isn’t a bad thing,” now “if you get misunderstandings, she goes to the police.”³⁷ Conversely, many female respondents expressed gratitude that the UPF “comes and checks on the family,”³⁸ and insisted that abusive men should be “taken to the police and it disciplines [them].”³⁹

But some women were more ambivalent about the UPF’s role, even (or especially) in the case of gendered crimes. One woman claimed that “if you concentrate on reporting to the police, things get spoiled drastically;” instead, residents should “call old people for counseling.”⁴⁰ Another described the effects of police intervention as fleeting: “yes the police can intervene, at that moment you think things have ended, but immediately when they leave the partners start afresh.”⁴¹ A third said simply that “the government...can never reach in your bedroom to settle what’s there.”⁴² Perhaps consistent with these latter observations, in Table SI-25 we find no evidence of heterogeneous treatment effects by gender in Uganda.

Fourth, given UPF’s reputation as an ally and instrument of the ruling NRM party, COP could be more impactful in NRM strongholds, where citizens may be more receptive to increased police proximity. It is also possible that UPF officers discriminate against opponents of the ruling party when responding to citizens’ complaints, limiting the effectiveness of COP except in NRM strongholds. But this does not appear to be the case either, as shown in Table SI-26. While we find some evidence that the program was associated with a larger increase in the frequency of interactions between citizens and the UPF in NRM strongholds, we do not find that the program was otherwise more successful in these areas. Perhaps not coincidentally, themes of partisan bias and political influence did not arise once in any of the FGDs.

Fifth, the program may only be effective among citizens who were directly exposed to it. Our baseline and endline surveys consist of randomly selected residents from each study village. While we find a positive and statistically significant treatment effect on the frequency of contact between these residents and the UPF, many respondents in our sample likely did not interact with UPF officers, and some may not have known of the program’s existence, potentially diminishing its efficacy.

Of course, as Blair et al. (2021) argue, if COP is to fulfill its promise, its effects must extend beyond the relatively small pool of residents who interact with police officers during COP activities. Nonetheless, if Uganda’s COP intervention was effective *at least* among those who were directly exposed to it, then it could plausibly reshape police-community relations more broadly if it were scaled up further.

To probe this possibility, we replicate all our analyses using only our sample of LC1 chairpeople. As discussed above, qualitative field reports suggest that LC1 chairpeople were almost always present during town hall meetings. LC1 chairpeople are also responsible for helping to organize NWTs, and more generally for serving as liaisons between their communities and the police⁴³—a role that many described in detail, and mostly positively, in the FGDs. As one village leader explained, “last year police would come here and you find they’re okay...so we don’t have a reason to fear police in this village like the way it used to be years back.”⁴⁴ However, as we show in SI Section I, we do not find evidence that the COP program was more successful in our LC1 sample. Not surprisingly, Table SI-35 shows that the estimated first stage effect on the compliance index is more than twice as large among LC1 chairpeople as among randomly sampled citizens. Yet LC1 chairpeople in treatment villages appear to be no more likely to report crime, no more knowledgeable of the criminal justice system, and, if anything, less optimistic in their assessments of the police than those in control villages.⁴⁵

The demand-side analyses thus yield little evidence of treatment effect heterogeneity. There are a few exceptions: for example, the positive effect on crime reporting appears to be smaller among respondents who reported feeling intimidated by the police at baseline (Table SI-22) and (weakly) larger among those who expressed higher baseline levels of satisfaction with the police (Table SI-23). The positive effect on reporting of police misconduct also seems (weakly) smaller among respondents who felt intimidated at baseline (Table SI-22). However, these statistically significant results are few, and we are cautious not to over-interpret them given that most of our estimates do not reach conventional levels of statistical significance. Taken together, we find limited evidence that observable demand-side characteristics meaningfully moderate the program’s effects. While these analyses cannot rule out more complex or unmeasured mechanisms, they suggest that variation along the dimensions we are able to observe is unlikely to account for the study’s null ITTs.

7.3. Supply-side explanations

Next, we consider several potential “supply-side” obstacles to COP related to the structure and capacity of the UPF. (Again, these analyses were not pre-specified.) First and most obviously, UPF stations may lack the resources to implement COP successfully (Musiime, 2012). COP is resource-intensive: it requires that rank-and-file officers establish a frequent physical presence in the communities they serve (Skogan, 2006), and that they work with communities to solve problems that generate fear, insecurity, and disorder, even when those problems seem only tangentially related to crime. These activities require resources that the average UPF station may not have.

While we did not interview police officers in our FGDs, in many cases citizens’ grievances against the UPF were connected to a lack of resources among UPF stations. For example, respondents complained that

³³ T4102033043, men, February 14, 2019.

³⁴ T4102033043, men, February 14, 2019.

³⁵ C4101982983, women, February 15, 2019.

³⁶ T4102033043, men, February 14, 2019.

³⁷ T4102033043, men, February 14, 2019.

³⁸ C4101982983, women, February 15, 2019.

³⁹ C4101982983, women, February 15, 2019.

⁴⁰ C4101982983, women, February 15, 2019.

⁴¹ C4101982983, women, February 15, 2019.

⁴² T4102033043, women, February 14, 2019.

⁴³ Note, of course, that while the responses of LC1 chairpeople capture direct exposure to the intervention, they may not proxy for effects on the community writ large. We use our random sample of residents for the latter purpose.

⁴⁴ T4102033043, leaders, February 14, 2019.

⁴⁵ In SI Section F.5 we also show that our null results are robust to the estimation of complier average causal effects (CACE) using various definitions of individual-level compliance among randomly selected residents. But these results should be interpreted with caution due to potential exclusion restriction violations, as we discuss in SI Section F.5.

“when thieves come to steal and we report to them, they take like six hours to reach here,”⁴⁶ or that “police officers have not helped us because they say that they are few,”⁴⁷ or that “at night you can bring a culprit when there is no one at the station.”⁴⁸ We explore the consequences of resource constraints more formally by testing for treatment effect heterogeneity among stations above and below the median on an index of resources.⁴⁹ (This analysis is robust to using the 25th or 75th percentile as the cutoff instead.) As shown in Table SI-27, we find little evidence that Uganda’s COP program was more effective among stations that had more abundant resources at baseline.

Second, we consider the possibility that turnover among rank-and-file UPF officers diminished the effectiveness of COP in Uganda. Turnover can undermine community policing by complicating officers’ efforts to establish rapport with citizens. However, conditioning on turnover must be interpreted cautiously: if the COP program itself affected reassignment patterns, estimates that stratify by turnover risk post-treatment bias. Although we find no evidence that treatment assignment predicts turnover (Tables SI-4 and SI-5), these heterogeneous treatment effect estimates should be interpreted as descriptive rather than strictly causal. With this caveat in mind, we find little evidence that COP was more effective in stations with lower turnover rates (Table SI-28).

Third, we investigate whether the null effects may have resulted from principal-agent problems. COP is time-consuming, and rank-and-file officers may have incentives to revert to more passive approaches to policing if their supervisors do not monitor their performance (Peeters and Campos, 2023). In a setting like Uganda, where many stations are far from their respective district headquarters and where rough roads, resource constraints, and unreliable cell phone networks make it difficult to track rank-and-file officers’ behavior (Wagner et al., 2020), principal-agent problems may have encouraged shirking and undermined implementation. Yet in Table SI-29, we find little evidence that Uganda’s COP program was more impactful in stations closer to district headquarters, where barriers to monitoring were likely less severe. As we show in Table SI-30, we similarly find little evidence that the program was more successful among stations with fewer officers from the lowest ranks of the UPF, who may have been more prone to shirking due to their inexperience.

Finally, we consider officer morale as an obstacle to the effectiveness of the COP intervention. Previous studies of COP have documented resistance to its adoption among rank-and-file officers, even in high-income countries (Mastrofski et al., 2007). In our setting, it is possible that UPF officers felt so overwhelmed or were so opposed to COP that it was impossible to motivate them to properly engage with the program even in places where monitoring capacity was relatively high. Yet, as Figure SI-1 shows, officers in our baseline survey overwhelmingly agreed that information from citizens is important to police work and that mechanisms to establish closer relations with communities (here, foot patrols) are effective. In other words, officers appear to have valued both the goals and the mechanisms of COP.

That said, the figure also suggests that officers felt somewhat overwhelmed at baseline: roughly half of the officers agreed that their station received too many criminal complaints, and 83% agreed that expectations for community engagement were too high, even before the intervention began. On the one hand, these responses show that social desirability concerns did not prevent officers from expressing negative opinions, which increases our trust in the positive views that officers

voiced about COP. On the other hand, these responses point to the possibility that our null results may be driven by officers feeling disgruntled, perhaps because COP added even more to their workload.

As Figure SI-2 shows, however, we do not see a consistent increase in officers’ sense of being overwhelmed from baseline to endline in either the treatment or the control group.⁵⁰ Moreover, the vast majority of officers in our endline survey still agreed that COP is “worth the effort” rather than being “too much of a burden” (98%) and that foot patrols are “a good use of time” (94%). Finally, in Tables SI-31 and SI-32 we find limited evidence that COP was more effective in places where officer morale was relatively high and where officers were most positive about COP at baseline. While these heterogeneous treatment effect analyses are exploratory and less well-powered than our ITT estimates, they suggest that observable variation in officer morale and other supply-side factors does not generate substantively larger (or smaller) treatment effects within the range observed in our sample.

7.4. Flawed program design and implementation?

We also consider the possibility that the UPF’s COP program was more fundamentally flawed in either its design or implementation (or both). It is possible that the program included too few components of COP, and that it would have been more effective if it had also incorporated, for example, citizen police academies or in-service training for UPF officers. It is likewise possible that the program would have been more effective if the UPF had implemented its existing components more aggressively—for example, by organizing larger or more frequent town hall meetings, or by conducting longer, more regular, and more visible foot patrols.

Ultimately, we cannot rule out these possibilities. But there are several reasons for skepticism. First, as we show in Table 1, the UPF’s COP program was intensive enough to generate statistically significant increases in citizens’ reports of town hall meetings and NWT activities, even after the intervention was complete, and even among randomly sampled community residents who may or may not have participated in those activities. We provide further evidence of the scope and intensity of the intervention in SI Section F.5. Moreover, Table SI-35 shows that the program produced similarly disappointing results even among the LC1 chairpeople who were exposed to it most directly and intensely.

Second, past studies have shown that even less robust COP-style interventions can yield promising results. Peyton et al. (2019), for example, find that a single door-to-door “meet and greet” visit lasting no more than 10 min on average and reaching just 41% of targeted (treatment) households was sufficient to improve residents’ perceptions of police legitimacy and increase their willingness to cooperate and comply with police directives in New Haven, CT. More broadly, in their systematic review, Gill et al. (2014, 420) find that COP increases citizens’ satisfaction with the police and improves their perceptions of police legitimacy, even though some COP activities “did not actually happen during the intervention period” under study. Taking these observations together, while the UPF appears to have implemented some components of the program more faithfully than others, the intervention as a whole seems to have been sufficiently strong that we could reasonably expect it to produce detectable treatment effects on our outcomes of interest.

Third, the UPF carefully and deliberately tailored its program to the realities of policing in Uganda, including the tight resource constraints under which the UPF has long operated. The COP manual that resulted from the UPF’s deliberations enjoyed high-level buy-in from UPF leadership and the Ugandan government more generally. It is unclear what the path to a more robust COP program might be without a dramatic

⁴⁶ C4101982983, men, February 15, 2019.

⁴⁷ T2032383841, men, February 15, 2019.

⁴⁸ T2032383841, women, February 15, 2019.

⁴⁹ The index comprises baseline measures of the number of officers and motorbikes for consistency at each station, the size of the station’s monthly fuel allowance, the availability of a crime registration book, and the condition of the station diary.

⁵⁰ These results should be interpreted with care, since the composition of our officer sample changed substantially between baseline and endline due to officer turnover.

infusion of resources to purchase more equipment, hire more officers, and build more infrastructure throughout rural regions of the country. In our conversations with UPF leadership, they made it clear that this was not a viable option, and that their goal was to explore ways to improve police-community relations within existing (and rather tight) resource constraints. In any event, given the results we report in this paper, and given that similar null results have been observed in countries that have the capacity to invest more resources into their COP programs—such as Brazil (Barbosa et al., 2024), Colombia (Hanson et al., 2025), and the Philippines (Nanes, Ravanilla and Haim, 2023)—it is not evident that a more intensive intervention would have produced more beneficial effects.

8. Discussion and conclusion

We conclude by considering the external validity and practical implications of our findings. It is, of course, possible that COP is an effective mechanism for improving police-community relations and reducing crime when the conditions are optimal, but that optimal conditions simply do not exist in rural Uganda. Even the most generously resourced police stations in our sample operate under severe logistical and staffing constraints, and the broader political context may limit citizens' willingness to engage with the police. It is therefore plausible that COP could yield different results in institutional environments that differ substantially from the one we study here.

At the same time, many of the constraints we document in Uganda—such as limited resources, high turnover, weak monitoring capacity, and politicized policing—are common in low-income countries and authoritarian regimes (Brogden and Nijhar, 2013). Moreover, within our sample we observe meaningful variation along these dimensions, yet we find little evidence that stations with more favorable observable characteristics experienced substantively larger treatment effects. While we cannot rule out the possibility that COP would perform better under substantially different institutional conditions, our evidence suggests that marginal improvements along the dimensions we observe would likely be insufficient to generate large gains in trust or public safety.

More broadly, given that Uganda falls near the median of the distribution of police capacity (as measured by police personnel per capita) across countries in sub-Saharan Africa (Fig. 1), we expect that similar constraints may limit the effectiveness of COP in many other LICs that have adopted it in recent years. This is indeed the finding reported by Blair et al.'s (2021) meta-analysis of six COP RCTs (including ours) in the Global South, as well as qualitative studies of community policing in Ethiopia (Di Nunzio, 2014), Kenya (Ruteere and Pommerolle, 2003), Mozambique (Kyed, 2009), and South Africa (Brogden, 2002).

From a practical perspective, our findings cast doubt on the prospect that Uganda's COP program could have been made substantially more effective simply by addressing the supply- or demand-side obstacles we examine. Within the range of variation present in our sample, we find limited evidence that the program was more successful among stations with more resources, lower turnover, better monitoring conditions, more experienced officers, or higher officer morale. Similarly, we find limited evidence that it was more successful among regime supporters or among sub-groups who might plausibly have benefited disproportionately from increased police presence—women, for example. Nor do we find evidence that our null findings are driven by ceiling effects or by our sampling of respondents who were not directly exposed to the intervention. Taken together, these results suggest that tactical adjustments to COP may be insufficient to produce large improvements in police-community relations or public safety in settings like the one we study here.

It is also possible that other factors limited the impact of Uganda's COP program in ways we are unable to detect in our data. We empirically explore a wide variety of potential supply- and demand-side explanations for our generally disappointing results. However, there are

other possibilities we do not consider, and cannot test. For example, the success of COP may depend on structural and cultural transformation within the police force as a whole in order to overcome deep citizen distrust (Musiime, 2012), especially where the police are perceived as abusive, corrupt, or politicized (FES, 2020). Granted, studies from the Global North have found a positive correlation between COP interventions and citizens' attitudes towards the police, even in the absence of a "philosophical shift" in "departmental priorities" (Gill et al., 2014, 405). Nevertheless, philosophical and cultural shifts may be more necessary in an authoritarian, low-income country like Uganda.⁵¹ It is also possible that restoring police-community relations in settings like Uganda requires even more systemic forms of social and political change—progress towards democratization, for example, or towards reconciliation between rival ethnic, religious, or partisan groups—to help mitigate some of the underlying causes of citizen distrust. We find this plausible, though ultimately we cannot be sure.

If this is the case, however, it would only provide more reason for skepticism towards the many COP initiatives currently being undertaken throughout the Global South (for a similar position, see Brogden and Nijhar, 2013). Deep institutional and philosophical reform within police forces is complex and rare, requires tremendous political will, and typically occurs only in the wake of protracted civil crises (e.g., Blair, 2020). Democratization, reconciliation, and other forms of social and political change are rarer and more difficult still. If transformation of this sort is a prerequisite for COP to succeed in most LICs, then the prospects for most existing COP initiatives are likely dim. Failed attempts to implement COP programs in autocracies such as Ethiopia (Di Nunzio, 2014) and Mozambique (Kyed, 2009) are thus instructive. We encourage researchers and practitioners to further examine these and other possible scope conditions for successful COP interventions.

From a policy perspective, our findings offer several important implications. First, governments considering COP packages centered on tactics such as town hall meetings, foot patrols, and neighborhood watch teams should be cautious about expecting measurable gains in trust, cooperation, or public safety in low-income or authoritarian country settings, especially without complementary reforms. Increased contact alone may not be sufficient to shift deeply rooted perceptions or behaviors. Second, if governments pursue COP-style interventions in environments where accountability for police misconduct is low, policymakers should recognize that increasing contact between citizens and the police may also expand opportunities for informal payments or other forms of abuse unless credible oversight mechanisms are put in place. In settings such as Uganda, where constraints on accountability are longstanding and politically embedded, strengthening such mechanisms is neither simple nor purely technical. Our findings therefore suggest that community engagement initiatives implemented in isolation, without parallel efforts to improve transparency, supervision, and redress for grievances, may carry risks alongside potential benefits.

Third, our findings suggest that policymakers may wish to test and compare alternative or complementary initiatives that target police officer behavior more directly. These initiatives—particularly when implemented with sufficient intensity or saturation—may be more likely to improve police conduct and strengthen police-community relations. In Rajasthan, India, for example, Banerjee et al. (2021) find that recurring "decoy visits" by mock crime victims increased police officers' politeness towards subsequent victims. Three days of "soft skills" training—focused on communication, mediation, stress management, motivation, leadership, and other themes—likewise improved officers' politeness and increased the satisfaction of real crime victims, especially as the proportion of officers trained in a given station rose above 50%. Similarly, in Mexico City, Canales et al. (2025) find that three days of "procedural justice" training improved both attitudinal

⁵¹ Local scholars of policing in Uganda, such as Musiime (2012), have reached a similar conclusion.

and behavioral measures of fairness, empathy, transparency, and responsiveness towards citizens. While the intervention we study also involved training, it was shorter, emphasized different themes, and required officers to adopt new policing practices that some may have found prohibitively time- and labor-intensive. Whether interventions like these would succeed in Uganda—which is much poorer than either India or Mexico, with a more authoritarian government and a more politicized police force—is an open question. Nevertheless, policymakers in low-income country settings may benefit from experimentally evaluating such strategies alongside, or in place of, the tactical COP programs that continue to proliferate throughout the Global South.

Credit authorship contribution statement

Robert A. Blair: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Supervision, Software, Resources, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Guy Grossman:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Supervision, Software, Resources, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Anna M. Wilke:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Supervision, Software, Resources, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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Appendix A. Supplementary data

Supplementary data to this article can be found online at <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.worlddev.2026.107502>

Data availability

All data and replication code have been posted to a public repository.

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